St. Joseph's Anglo-Chinese School
F.5 English Language
Grammar – Lesson 4: Cleft sentences

Cleft sentences

Part 1: Proofreading quiz

Each paragraph contains FIVE errors. The errors include relative clauses, inverted patterns and nominalisation. Proofread the paragraphs.

Technology has undoubtedly made our generation lazier. Not only we spend hours scrolling through social media, but we also order every meal through delivery apps, which means we never leave the house. Students, which live near school, still take the bus because walking seems too much effort. Rarely teenagers read a book when they can watch a video summary in five minutes. The important of exercising regularly is something that many of us have forgotten. Only by admitting the problem we can start to build healthier habits.

Technology has not made us lazier; it has simply changed the way we work. What critics fail to understand is that apps save us time for more valuable activities. Not only students can complete their homework faster with online tools, but they also use the time they save to learn new skills, that explains why so many teenagers now know how to edit videos. The belief that young people do nothing meaningful on their phones is wrong, because many of them, which run successful online businesses, started from nothing. The significant of these digital skills should not be ignored, as they prepare us for the modern workplace. Only when we accept that technology is a tool we can stop blaming it for our own lack of discipline.

Teacher's answers

Item	Correction
1A	Not only do we spend hours scrolling through social media... (Move 'do' before the subject — 'Not only' inverts.)
2A	Students, who live near school... ('which' → 'who' — a relative pronoun for people is needed.)
3A	Rarely do teenagers read a book... (Move 'do' before the subject — 'Rarely' inverts.)
4A	The importance of exercising regularly... ('important' → 'importance' — a noun is needed after 'the'.)
5A	Only by admitting the problem can we start... (Move 'can' before the subject — 'Only by' inverts.)
1B	Not only can students complete their homework... (Move 'can' before the subject — 'Not only' inverts.)
2B	...learn new skills, which explains why so many teenagers... ('that' → 'which' — a relative pronoun is needed after a comma.)
3B	...many of them, who run successful online businesses... ('which' → 'who' — a relative

	pronoun for people is needed.)
4B	The significance of these digital skills... (‘significant’ → ‘significance’ — a noun is needed after ‘the’.)
5B	Only when we accept that technology is a tool can we stop... (Move ‘can’ before the subject — ‘Only when’ inverts.)

Part 2: Cleft sentences in formal writing

A cleft sentence breaks one idea into two parts so the most important information stands out. Study the patterns below.

Example 1: It-cleft – focusing on the cause

Plain:	People communicate less because they use messaging apps.
More formal:	It is messaging apps that make people communicate less.

Young people used to meet at the park after school, but now everyone sends messages from their bedrooms. A quick text is easier than a real conversation, so face-to-face friendships have become rare. It is messaging apps that make people communicate less, and this change will only grow deeper as technology advances.

Example 2: It-cleft – setting up a contrast

Plain:	Some people blame social media, but smartphones cause the real problem.
More formal:	While some people blame social media, it is smartphones that cause the real problem.

Every day there are news stories about the dangers of social media. While some people blame social media, it is smartphones that cause the real problem. Without a phone in their pocket, teenagers could not check their accounts every five minutes.

Example 3: Wh-cleft – presenting a recommendation

Plain:	Schools should teach students how to communicate face to face.
More formal:	What schools should do is teach students how to communicate face to face.

Many teachers complain that their students cannot hold a proper conversation. What schools should do is teach students how to communicate face to face. A single workshop on active listening would help teenagers rebuild the skills that messaging apps have quietly taken away.

Example 4: All-cleft – naming the only thing needed

Plain:	Teenagers only need one real conversation to remember the value of talking.
More formal:	All teenagers need is one real conversation to remember the value of

	talking.

Parents often buy expensive devices or hire tutors to help their children socially. All teenagers need is one real conversation to remember the value of talking. Once they experience the warmth of genuine human connection, the cold comfort of emojis will seem far less appealing.

Part 3: Practice sets

Rewrite each simple sentence as a cleft sentence. The sentences are about technology and communication, so keep the register formal. Sets 1–4 are straightforward; sets 5–8 require you to change the part of speech.

Example Set 1 (It-cleft – the cause)

Simple sentence:	Teenagers send short messages because they are afraid of real conversations.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'It is the fear of real conversations …'.*
Teacher's Answer:	It is the fear of real conversations that makes teenagers send short messages.

Example Set 2 (Wh-cleft – what is needed)

Simple sentence:	Students need to practise face-to-face communication.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'What students need to do …'.*
Teacher's Answer:	What students need to do is practise face-to-face communication.

Example Set 3 (It-cleft – the contrast)

Simple sentence:	People blame social media, but modern phones are the real problem.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'While people blame social media …'.*
Teacher's Answer:	While people blame social media, it is modern phones that are the real problem.

Example Set 4 (All-cleft – the only thing needed)

Simple sentence:	Teenagers only need one proper conversation to understand the value of talking.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'All teenagers need …'.*
Teacher's Answer:	All teenagers need is one proper conversation to understand the value of talking.

Example Set 5 (It-cleft – the cause, word-form change)

Simple sentence:	People feel brave when they insult others online because they are anonymous.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'It is the anonymity …'.*
Teacher's Answer:	It is the anonymity of the internet that makes people feel brave when they insult others online.

Example Set 6 (It-cleft – the contrast, word-form change)

Simple sentence:	People think technology is convenient, but it actually destroys our patience.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'While people think technology is convenient …'.*
Teacher's Answer:	While people think technology is convenient, it is the convenience of modern devices that destroys our patience.

Example Set 7 (Wh-cleft – the recommendation, word-form change)

Simple sentence:	Schools should make students aware that talking face to face is important.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'What schools should do …'.*
Teacher's Answer:	What schools should do is make students aware of the importance of talking face to face.

Example Set 8 (All-cleft – the only thing needed, word-form change)

Simple sentence:	Teenagers only need to be confident for one minute to start a real conversation.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'All teenagers need …'.*
Teacher's Answer:	All teenagers need is the confidence to start a real conversation.

Part 4: Writing Task

Instructions:

1. Write ONE paragraph (about 80 words) explaining the influence of artificial intelligence on students, and suggesting ONE thing schools could do to help.

→ Use **ONE cleft sentence** (It is … that … / What … is … / All … needs to do is …).

→ Use a relative clause or an inverted pattern e.g. Not only … / Never … / Rarely …

Sample answer 1 (It-cleft) Artificial intelligence is changing the way students learn, but not every change is positive. It is the loss of independent thinking that worries teachers most, as too many teenagers now let apps write their essays without even reading the questions first. Schools should therefore limit AI use in all homework tasks, which would force students to develop their own ideas and opinions. A simple rule requiring a first draft without AI would restore the value of real effort.

Sample answer 2 (Wh-cleft) What concerns parents most is that their children are losing the ability to think for themselves. Artificial intelligence can answer almost any question instantly, so students no longer wrestle with difficult problems on their own. Schools should require students to complete at least one draft without any AI assistance of any kind, which would teach them the patience that genuine learning demands. Only then will they understand that struggle is not failure but the beginning of real growth.

Sample answer 3 (All-cleft) All schools need to do is teach students how to use AI as a tool rather than a replacement for thinking. Many teenagers now trust an app more than their own judgment, which means they never develop the confidence to solve problems alone. A short practical lesson on verifying AI answers with real sources would show students that true intelligence is not about speed but about understanding. This small change could transform the way they approach every subject.

Each sample uses ONE cleft: Sample 1 an it-cleft (It is … that …), Sample 2 a wh-cleft (What … is …) and Sample 3 an all-cleft (All … need to do is …). Each sample also contains at least ONE relative clause or inverted pattern — point these out to students before they write.